

■ By Sandeep Unnithan

Last month, 25-year-old Sarita walked into the Haryana Police Headquarters in Panchkula with her two daughters in her arms. As policemen looked on, she drank a bottle of poison. Her distraught step was against the Rohtak police's refusal to register a case against their colleagues. Sarita had been raped by two policemen in April. The final act of despair was perhaps a citizen's strongest statement of the lack of faith in a state police force. Chief Minister Bhupinder Singh Hooda's hasty move to immediately hand the case over to the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) did not inspire any confidence in the Haryana Police either.

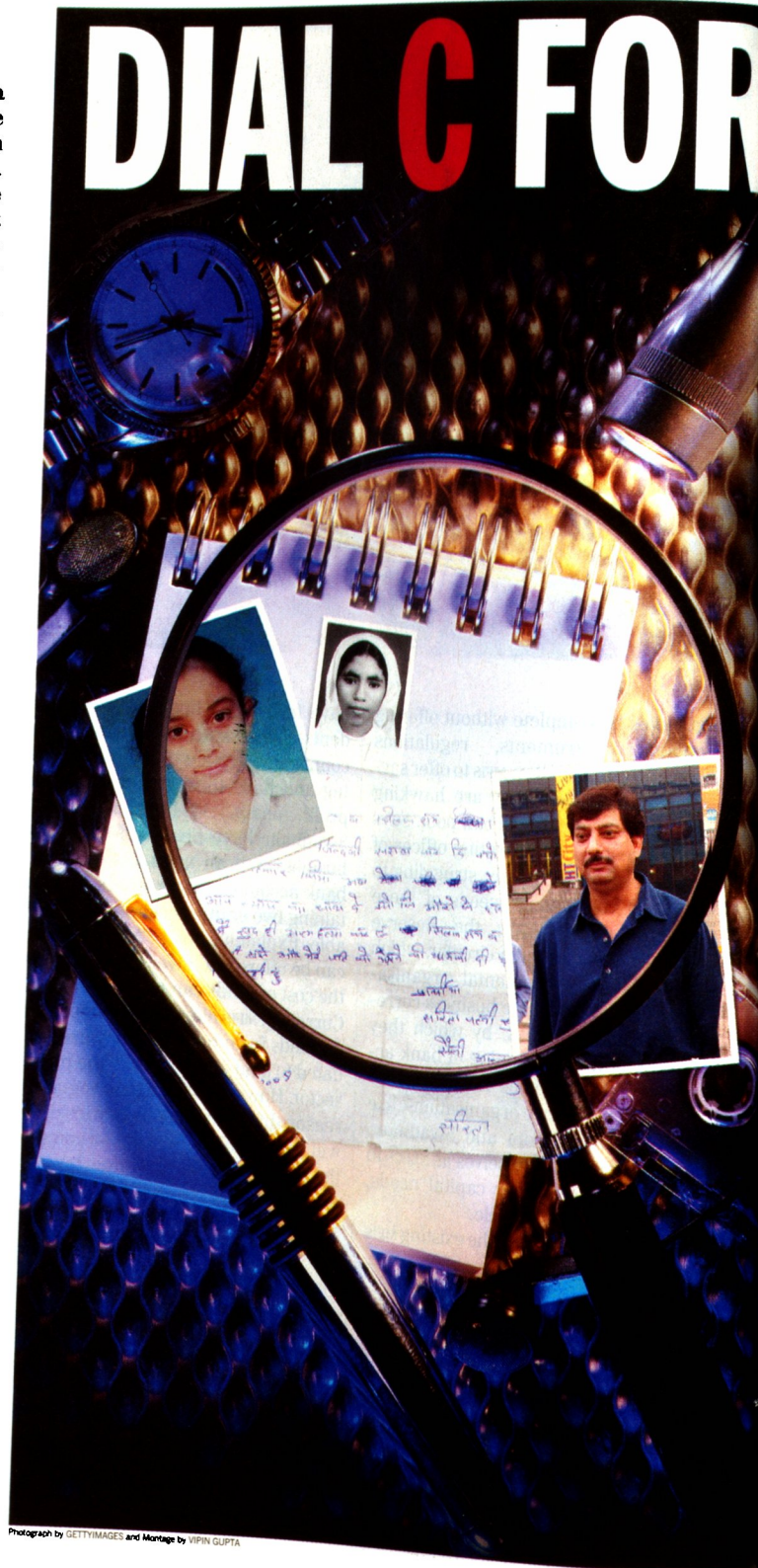
The speed of Hooda's action surprised even the state Government—it came even before his Government could file a reply before the high court on the conduct of investigations into the Sarita suicide case. But then, this is now a standard operating procedure for most state governments. Saddled with a botched-up investigation or a politically sensitive case? Dial the CBI.

Call them hot potato handlers. In recent months, the CBI has been handling an increasing number of high-profile cases from states—the twin murders of Aarushi Talwar and Hemraj in Noida, the murder of ACP Rajbir Singh and the mysterious death of British teenage tourist Scarlett Keeling in Goa. Most of these homicides fit for investigation by the state Criminal Investigation Departments (CIDs) are now being handled by the Central agency.

In Uttar Pradesh, for instance, Chief Minister Mayawati recommended as many as nine cases to the CBI in the past year—unprecedented in the state's history. While referring a frivolous dowry demand complaint against Union HRD Minister Arjun Singh's family to the CBI, the Uttar Pradesh Government did not even wait for the police to conduct a preliminary inquiry.

"The image of police in some states is at such an all-time low that nothing short of calling in the CBI for even routine investigations can inspire public confidence," says Prakash Singh, former DGP, Uttar Pradesh, and

DIAL C FOR



Photograph by GETTY IMAGES and Montage by VIPIN GUPTA